

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 4 · FRAME

Where the film puts things, and what it leaves out.

SUNSET BLVD.

In the Mood for Love · 2000 · 98 min · dir. Wong Kar-wai ·
Cantonese · watch with subtitles on

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

Two filmmakers who never put anything in the frame by accident, using that control for opposite reasons. Wes Anderson puts the most important thing dead centre and builds the world around it like a dollhouse. Wong Kar-wai pushes his lovers to the edges, behind doors, into corridors and mirrors, and leaves the middle of the frame empty.

One frame shows you everything. The other hides half of it. Both are breaking the same rule, from opposite sides.

SUNSET BLVD.

IN THE MOOD FOR LOVE

2000 · 98 min · dir. Wong Kar-wai · Cantonese · watch with subtitles on

Hong Kong, 1962. Two neighbours in a crowded apartment building discover that their husband and wife are having an affair with each other, and slowly, carefully, fall into something they refuse to call love.

Why it is on the ballot. Where Anderson centres everything, Wong hides it. His two leads are squeezed into doorways, cut off by walls, caught in mirrors and through windows. The frame keeps them apart even when they are standing next to each other, and the empty space says what they will not.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THERE WAS NO FINISHED SCRIPT

Wong shot on and off for roughly fifteen months, handing actors pages on the morning of the shoot, and cut a great deal at the end — including an intimate scene between the two leads. He has said he would cut them again: the film is about absence.

OLD HONG KONG WAS ALREADY GONE

Significant parts of it — street exteriors, corridors, hotel material — were shot in older districts of Bangkok, because by 2000 almost nothing in Hong Kong still looked like the Hong Kong of 1962.

CRITICS NOW RANK IT AMONG THE GREATEST FILMS EVER MADE

In the 2022 *Sight and Sound* poll, voted by 1,639 critics, programmers and academics, it placed fifth of all time, up from 24th ten years earlier. Tony Leung won Best Actor at Cannes for it in 2000.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THROUGHOUT

Count the frames inside the frame

Doorways, window bars, mirrors, stairwell railings, curtains. Most shots of the two of them are taken through something.

Why it matters: They are always watched, always boxed in. In a building this crowded, every conversation has an audience, and the framing makes you part of it.

THE HUSBAND AND THE WIFE

Where are their faces?

You hear the two spouses and see the backs of their heads. The film never shows either face.

Why it matters: The frame decides who matters. The people having the affair are left out of their own story.

THE WALK TO THE NOODLE STALL

Slow motion, same music, different dress

She goes down the same steps with the same tin, to the same waltz, several times over. The dresses, all designed and sourced by William Chang — who was also the production designer and the editor — are how you tell the passes apart.

Why it matters: The only sign that weeks are going by is her wardrobe. The film tells time with costume and framing, not dialogue.

THE REHEARSALS

Is this real?

At one point she confronts her husband, and it is not what it seems.

Why it matters: The framing lets you believe it before the film tells you what you are actually looking at. The camera keeps secrets too.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

Room 2046

The hotel room where they meet to write is number 2046. Wong's next film, *2046*, returns to the same man years later.

OPEN

The music is borrowed

The waltz over every slow walk is "Yumeji's Theme" by Shigeru Umebayashi, written for Seijun Suzuki's *Yumeji* in 1991. Three Nat King Cole songs in Spanish carry the rest, including "Quizás, Quizás, Quizás."

OPEN

The ending is a whisper you cannot hear

In 1966, far from Hong Kong, a man speaks a secret into a hollow in a wall at Angkor Wat and seals it with mud. The film frames the moment and never lets you hear it. It is the last thing it chooses to leave outside the frame.

- 01 The film almost never puts the two of them together in the centre of the frame. What did that do to you?
- 02 You never see the spouses' faces. Did you want to, and what would it have changed?
- 03 Anderson's frame shows you everything. Wong's hides half of it. Which one told you more?

Where to watch

Find it here → [In the Mood for Love on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Criterion · TCM · BFI · Sight and Sound · CNN

THE LESSON

DIVIDE BY THREE

AN ENGRAVER DESCRIBED A HABIT

In 1797 an English engraver named John Thomas Smith published *Remarks on Rural Scenery*, about painting landscapes. He noticed painters tended to divide a picture in proportions of about two thirds to one third — how much sky against how much land — and named it, with an apology: “Analogous to this ‘Rule of thirds,’ (if I may be allowed so to call it) I have presumed to think that, in connecting or in breaking the various lines of a picture, it would likewise be a good rule to do it, in general, by a similar scheme of proportion.”

THE CAMERA MADE IT A LAW

Photography manuals picked it up, film schools taught it, and eventually cameras and phones drew the grid onto the screen itself. Put the subject on a line, never in the middle. A tentative note about landscape painting became the first thing every beginner is told about the frame.

AND THE SCREEN ITSELF GOT A SHAPE

The American studios adopted the Academy aperture in 1931 and the Academy codified it the next year, giving the near-square 1.37:1 frame. When television arrived in the 1950s, cinema went wide to compete, and the frame has been changing shape ever since. The Grand Budapest Hotel uses that history as a clock.

THREE WAYS TO FILL A FRAME

ONE

THIRDS

The subject sits off-centre with room to look or move into. It feels natural and balanced, which is why it became the rule.

Almost everything

TWO

DEAD CENTRE

The subject sits in the middle, the world arranged symmetrically around it. Formal, controlled, a little unreal.

The Shining · Moonrise Kingdom · Mommy

THREE

FRAMES WITHIN FRAMES

Doorways, windows and mirrors cut the picture into smaller boxes and push people to the edges. Watched, hemmed in.

The Searchers · Carol · In the Mood for Love

Most films use all three in a single scene. What marks a filmmaker is which one they reach for when it matters.

TWO PIECES OF VOCABULARY

Aspect ratio is the shape of the frame, width against height: wider feels bigger and lonelier, squarer feels closer and more contained. **Negative space** is the empty part of the frame, which is never really empty — it is where the film puts the thing nobody is saying.

WHY THESE FILMS

Part Two starts with the most basic decision in filmmaking: where to put the camera, and what to leave out. Both films throw away the rule of thirds, one to show you a perfect world, the other to hide a private one.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Criterion, the BFI, TCM, the Design Museum, Variety and Smith's Remarks on Rural Scenery (1797). Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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